

did not make it to the World Cup sooner.

This will be Austria's first appearance at the tournament this century, and getting there was a story in itself. The Ralf Rangnick-led side won five matches on the bounce but lost to Romania in the sixth, leaving it one point short of direct qualification and facing Bosnia and Herzegovina in the final round.

It went behind in the 12th minute, but an equaliser from Michael Gregoritsch in the 77th minute saw Austria make it through. The side conceded just four goals across eight qualification matches.

Even more impressive was Austria's run to the knockout stages of Euro 2024 from a group that also contained France and the Netherlands, the latter suffering a 3-2 defeat.

But Austria was not the only team to make waves at the continental level.

Jordan defeated higher-ranked Japan, an Asian heavyweight and World Cup regular, 2-0 en route to the final against host Qatar.

It fell short in the title clash but built on that performance by finishing second in its qualification group behind South Korea. It heads to the World Cup with modest aspirations and nothing to lose.



Marcel Sabitzer (Austria)

The 32-year-old midfielder had a middling season with Borussia Dortmund but has dictated the tempo in the midfield with Austria. In the last year, Sabitzer has scored six goals and five assists in 11 appearances for the national team. In the absence of Christoph Baumgartner, Austria will turn to Sabitzer to set up the chances.



Musa Al-Taamari (Jordan)

Al-Taamari is just 28 and leads the team. The forward is one of the few Jordanians playing in Europe, representing Rennes in Ligue 1. He was the chief architect of the win over Japan, contributing a goal and an assist.

SQUADS

Argentina

Goalkeepers: Emiliano Martínez, Gerónimo Rulli, Juan Muso

Defenders: Leandro Balerdi, Nicolás Tagliafico, Gonzalo Montiel, Lisandro Martínez, Cristian Romero, Nicolás Otamendi, Facundo Medina, Nahuel Molina

Midfielders: Leandro Paredes, Rodrigo De Paul, Valentín Barco, Giovani Lo Celso, Exequiel Palacios, Alexis Mac Allister, Enzo Fernández

Forwards: Julián Álvarez, Lionel Messi, Nicolás González, Thiago Almada, Giuliano Simeone, Nico Paz, Lautaro Martinez, José Manuel López

Algeria

Goalkeepers: Luca Zidane, Oussama Benbot, Melvin Mastil

Defenders: Rafik Belghali, Samir Chergui, Rayan Aït-Nouri, Jaouen Hadjam, Aïssa Mandi, Ramy Bensebaini, Zineddine Belaïd, Achref Abada, Mohamed Amine Tougaï

Midfielders: Nabil Bentaleb, Hicham Boudaoui, Houssein Aouar, Farès Chaïbi, Ibrahim Maza, Yacine Titraoui, Ramiz Zerrouki

Forwards: Mohamed Amine Amoura, Nadhir Benbouali, Adil Boulbina, Farès Ghedjemis, Amine Gouiri, Anis Hadj Moussa, Riyad Mahrez

Austria

Goalkeepers: Patrick Pentz, Alexander Schlager, Florian Wiegele

Defenders: David Affengruber, David Alaba, Kevin Danso, Marco Friedl, Philipp Lienhart, Philipp Mwene, Stefan Posch, Alexander Prass, Michael Svoboda

Midfielders: Christoph Baumgartner, Carney Chukwuemeka, Florian Grillitsch, Konrad Laimer, Marcel Sabitzer, Xaver Schlager, Romano Schmid, Alessandro Schopf, Nicolas Seiwald, Paul Wanner, Patrick Wimmer

Forwards: Marko Arnautovic, Michael Gregoritsch, Sasa Kalajdzic

Jordan

Goalkeepers: Yazeed Abu Laila, Noor Bani Attiah, Abdullah Al-Fakhouri

Defenders: Mohammad Abu Hashhash, Abdullah Nasib, Hussam Abu Dhahab, Yazan Al-Arab, Mohammad Abu Al-Nadi, Salem Obeid, Saad Al-Rousan, Ehsan Haddad, Anas Badawi

Midfielders: Amer Jamous, Noor Al-Rawabdeh, Raja'i Ayed, Ibrahim Sa'adeh, Muhand Abu Taha, Nizar Al-Rashdan, Mohammad Al-Daoud

Forwards: Mohammad Abu Zureiq, Ali Olwan, Musa Al-Taamari, Oday Al-Fakhouri, Mahmoud Mardahi, Ibrahim Sabra, Ali Al-Azayzeh